

Worksheet — Spring Force Simulation

Simulation 05 • use with *Simulation - Spring force.html* • goes with Station 3 and the Forces investigation (spring)

Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

How to use this worksheet

Open **Simulation - Spring force.html** in a browser (it works offline). **Hang masses:** add 50 g at a time and read the pointer on the ruler. **Push / pull:** stretch or squash a spring on a table. The **Tasks** tab has the same three parts as this sheet; write your **explanations** here.

Part 1 before the lab (≈ 15 min) • **Part 2** during the lab (≈ 10 min) • **Part 3** homework (≈ 30 min).

Use $g = 9.81 \text{ N kg}^{-1}$. Extension x = pointer reading – unloaded reading. Always convert x to metres for k .

Part 1 — Pre-lab: predict, then test

Question	My prediction (before)	What the simulation showed	Physics explanation
1. A mass hangs at rest on the spring. Is the spring force bigger than, equal to or smaller than its weight?			
2. You double the load from 100 g to 200 g. What happens to the extension?			
3. You load the soft spring (limit $\approx 3 \text{ N}$) with 400 g, then unload it. What happens?			
4. You squash the spring by 6.0 cm. Which way does the spring push the block?			

5. Draw the free-body diagram of a 200 g mass hanging at rest on the spring.

Free-body diagram

6. The investigation spring has $k = 25.0 \text{ N m}^{-1}$. Calculate the extension (in cm) with 200 g hanging.

Working

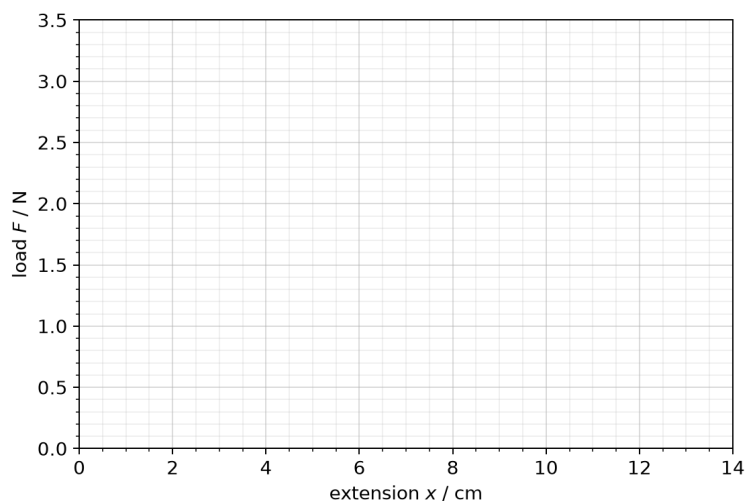
$x =$ _____ cm Sim check: _____ cm

Part 2 — During the lab: Station 3 / Forces investigation

Investigation spring, reading uncertainty ON. Record the sim values and your own measurements.

mass m / g (± 1)	load $F = mg$ / N	sim pointer / cm	sim x / cm (± 0.1)	our x / cm (± 0.1)
100				
150				
200				
250				
300				

7. Plot F against x with error bars ($\pm 0.1 \text{ cm}$). Draw the best-fit line and the steepest and shallowest lines through the error bars of the first and last points.



8. $k =$ _____ $\pm$ _____ N m^{-1} ($\Delta k = \frac{1}{2}(k_{\text{max}} - k_{\text{min}})$)

9. Mystery bag: $x =$ _____ cm $\Rightarrow F = kx =$ _____ N $\Rightarrow m =$ _____ kg. Balance: _____ kg

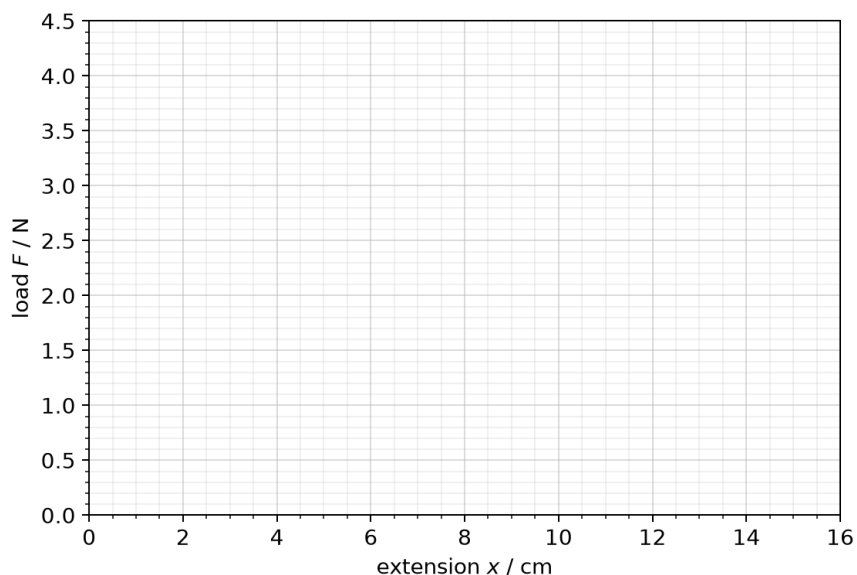
10. Would your method still work for a 5 kg load? Explain.

Part 3 — Homework: analyse

Station 3 spring, uncertainty ON. Record 100 g to 400 g in 50 g steps.

m / g	100	150	200	250	300	350	400
F / N							
x / cm							

11. Plot F against x with error bars and find $k \pm \Delta k$.



$k = \underline{\hspace{2cm}} \pm \underline{\hspace{2cm}} \text{ N m}^{-1}$

12. The investigation spring is stretched by 6.0 cm on a table. Calculate the spring force and give its direction. What does the minus sign in $F_H = -kx$ mean?

Working

13. The stiff spring ($k = 40.0 \text{ N m}^{-1}$) stretches 4.5 cm when an object hangs from it. Calculate the mass of the object.

Working

14. Sketch the F - x graph of a spring loaded past its limit of proportionality. Mark the limit of proportionality. Explain why an overloaded spring is no longer a good force meter.

Sketch and explanation